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Legislature Approves Bill to Protect Californians from Hate-Motivated, Antisemitic Violence

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During a shabbat service this January at Congregation Beth Israel in Colleyville, Texas, a gunman stormed into the synagogue, taking the congregants hostage for more than 11 hours. As the gunman made threats and demands, Rabbi Charlie Cytron-Walker kept his congregation calm, waiting for the right moment to strike the perpetrator with a chair and usher the victims to safety. Thanks to Cytron-Walker's expertise, everyone escaped safely.

In interviews following the incident, Cytron-Walker attributed his swift, decisive action to security training he had received from local nonprofit organizations.

More than a thousand miles away, California lawmakers took note.

The California State Legislature unanimously passed a measure in late August to strengthen protections for Californians facing hate-motivated violence. The bill, known as AB 1664, would expand the state's Nonprofit Security Grant Program, which provides funding for security enhancements at institutions at risk of hate-motivated violence.

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills), who authored the bill, said that it was introduced to the legislature in response to the standoff at Congregation Beth Israel. Gabriel cited a recent report from the California Attorney General that found a nearly 90 percent uptick in hate crimes in the state over the last decade as further reason to expand security protections at vulnerable community centers.

"In a world where hate crimes and antisemitism are on the rise, we need more than thoughts and prayers to keep us safe," said Gabriel. "This new law will provide critical resources to protect vulnerable communities and sends a powerful message that California stands firmly with those targeted by hate."

Gabriel initially authored legislation to create California's Nonprofit Security Grant Program in 2019, following a deadly shooting at Chabad of Poway. The program funds security enhancements at religious institutions, LGBTQ spaces, community centers, reproductive health facilities and other nonprofits deemed at risk of violence.

The Nonprofit Security Grant Program was originally slated to end in 2025. However, AB 1664 would extend the program's lifespan and strengthen its ability to keep communities safe, giving recipient institutions greater flexibility to use grant funding for initiatives like security training. This year's state budget included a $50 million allocation for the program, which was secured with the support of leaders and activists representing a broad coalition of vulnerable communities.

Jewish community leaders across the state have voiced their support for the bill—and for the continued funding of the Nonprofit Security Grant Program.

"In the midst of staggering levels of hate-motivated violence—targeting Jews and all vulnerable communities—we are fortunate to have the California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program to protect at-risk institutions from attacks," said David Bocarsly, Executive Director of the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California. "JPAC co-sponsored Assemblymember Gabriel's bill to establish the program in 2019 because we knew first-hand the value it would provide. Given the overwhelming demand for this resource, we are proud to co-sponsor AB 1664 to extend this program and expand it to include security training."

AB 1664 now heads to Gov. Gavin Newsom's desk for signature, where it must be acted upon by Sept. 30.

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